

1. Merchants and Trade in the Pre-Modern Era: Issues and Insights

DOWN THE CENTURIES, from times immemorial, the Indian Ocean had been at the centre of global maritime trade, both literally and figuratively, and was the conduit that linked the known world from the Mediterranean in the west to the South China Sea in the east. The Indian Ocean region extended from the west coast of Africa to South-East Asia, comprising a myriad of communities, religions and cultures. The ports on the east and west coasts of India, strategically located in the geographic centre of this region, became entrepôts of commercial exchange and of cultural diffusion since merchant ships from the west rarely sailed further east beyond the Bay of Bengal, while the ships from the east, especially China, did not venture further west than the ports of Kerala.

The graph contours of trade in the Indian Ocean survived with great stability over many centuries even after European nations had penetrated this trade circuit. Maritime trade, however, was only one part of the extended chain of trade which integrated regional and supra-local markets with ports and overseas markets, and merchants were the prime movers in this economic scenario.

Issues and insights

The nature of trade and merchant activity in the pre-medieval period gives rise to a number of questions and insights into historical institutional processes. At the most basic level, trading as a specialized activity carried on by a distinctive class of merchants implicitly indicates a diversified

economy which has expanded beyond subsistence; this holds true for production and consumption too. Production, even of primary goods like food grains, was oriented to non-local markets. Equally, trade promoted the production of a diverse range of manufactured goods for the market which resulted in the development of skills, basic technology and specialization. Consumption also expanded beyond what was produced or available locally. In short, trade became the engine of growth in the pre-modern world before the rise of industrial capitalism.

Risk was a factor of overriding importance in pre-modern trade. Mercantile organizations and institutions were primarily oriented to negotiating the risks involved in trade. There were two aspects to the risk factor. The first were the physical dangers of long-distance trade over land or sea. In overland trade, merchants constantly faced the dangers of unsafe roads and lack of security since the authority of the pre-medieval state rarely extended to remote areas, and overland trade routes could not be patrolled to provide safe passage to travellers. Overseas trade involved not merely the dangers of long sea voyages in primitive ships, but also necessitated prolonged stay in foreign ports for the merchants. The second aspect of the risk related to the paucity of information due to virtually non-existent communication technology. Merchants operated with minimal and mostly unreliable information about distant markets which had to be factored into their decisions on what and how much to buy and where and when to sell.

Seafaring in the pre-modern period, especially in the Indian Ocean, was driven by the pattern of monsoon winds and voyages had to be undertaken according to the seasonal winds. This imposed many limitations on travel and merchants perforce had to spend long periods residing in foreign ports to conduct their transactions before being able to return to their native places, resulting in the rise of trade diaspora in international ports. This pattern, in fact, was prevalent even up to the eighteenth century. Often, such merchant groups tended to become immigrant communities, living in enclaves in different ports. This led to two possible behavioural outcomes. First, there was a fierce determination among each group to retain its

cultural identity and individuality. Second, there was a tendency for cultural and social integration with the host society that led to the diffusion of religion and culture across many countries. In fact, the host societies also evinced the need to isolate foreign merchant communities to retain their own identity.¹ Evidence of such ethnic isolation and cultural diffusion is seen even now in the large numbers of Chinese communities in most ports in South-East Asia, the strong presence of Islam on the south-west coast of India and in Indonesia, the Hindu temples of Angkor in Cambodia, and the continuing influence of the Hindu epics *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata* and Sanskritized names even in the Islamic or Buddhist societies of South-East Asia. These cross-cultural interactions were important markers in mercantile history over the centuries.

Another determining factor is the role of the state in promoting trade. The state did not always suggest the presence of a strong, centralized authority. Institutions of the state included local bodies, corporate assemblies and regional authorities. The functioning of these institutions and their intervention in trade and mercantile activity needs to be explored as another facet of the conditions under which trade operated in pre-modern times.

Finally, we need to look at questions about merchants who were the main protagonists in pre-modern economies. What were the spheres of activity and interactions between functionally differentiated classes of merchants? What were their links to maritime trade? Did they own the ships used in coastal and maritime trade? Did their activities conform to the 'peddler' model of pre-modern intra-Asian trade?² The objective of this monograph is to study these issues as well as the complex dynamics of trade which flourished despite primitive technologies in production, transportation and communication in the ancient and medieval period with special reference to the Tamil merchants, state and society.

Tamil merchants and trade: A synopsis

Historical reconstruction of the past essentially depends on the sources available. For the ancient period, sources present two kinds of problems,

namely of the scarcity of data and the reliability of information. In the case of the Tamil country or Tamilakam, a rich corpus of literary works written in the early centuries of the Common Era during the Sangam period³ constitutes the main source. The use of literary sources is fraught with many pitfalls. To begin with, there is no chronological sequence or continuity in the sources. In using these sources we also have to make a judgement call on whether the poet was describing the reality of what he experienced or whether he was painting an idealized picture of the real world or whether the works pertained to any basic reality at all. Subject to these caveats, it can be said that the descriptions of ports, cities, trade and merchants in the *Pattupattu*, The Ten Songs, of the Sangam period, and the two epics *Silappadikaram* and *Manimekalai* of a somewhat later period have a vitality and vividness which lend themselves to historical analysis. Archaeological finds, especially of Roman coins and artefacts in many ports and inland areas of Tamilakam, support the information contained in the literary sources about the extent of trade with the Mediterranean region in the ancient period. The limited number of scattered inscriptions in Tamil Brahmi script is also useful as corroborative material. The source materials for this period are further enriched by the accounts of contemporary geographers of Rome and Alexandria like Strabo, Pliny and Ptolemy, in addition to *Periplus of the Erythrean Sea*, the first-hand anonymous account written in 75 CE.

For the early medieval period of the Pallava and Chola empires, inscriptions constitute the main source. Here there is no problem of volume or reliability. The published inscriptions alone run to tens of thousands. The challenge is to integrate the scattered information into meaningful analytical categories for understanding mercantile activity, behaviour and institutions.

In the ultimate analysis, we can derive a great deal of information which helps us to understand the nature of Tamil merchants and trade during the ancient and early modern periods. However, many questions remain unanswered, which means that our understanding can only be partial and our quest incomplete in some respects.

[Chapter 2](#) gives an account of merchants and trade in Tamilakam in the Sangam era. During this period the region was ruled by several chieftains or petty kings, in spite of the exaggerated references to the three great kingdoms of the Pandya, Chola and Chera. The fragmented political landscape was also subject to a high degree of instability because of frequent local wars. Despite this, we find that the region supported an extended seaborne trade from the Mediterranean to South-East Asia. A strong state was therefore not a prerequisite for mercantile activities to flourish as long as the latter were allowed to function freely without extortionate taxation, controls or other state intervention. The evidence suggests that in Tamilakam merchants were not a homogeneous group or class. Different classes of merchants trading in diverse markets and goods, ranging from craftsmen who peddled their own products to maritime merchants, integrated a hierarchy of markets from the local to the regional to the external and overseas markets. The goods traded covered a vast range of utility and luxury products from food grains and pepper to cloth, aromatic substances and precious gems like corals and pearls, which would seem effectively to counter the model which characterized Asian trade as ‘peddling trade’ restricted to inconsequential luxuries.

[Chapter 3](#) gives a brief account of the rise of the major kingdoms of Tamilakam—the Pallavas based in Kanchipuram and later the extensive and strong Chola kingdom based in Tanjavur. The rise of these kingdoms stabilized the political scenario of the region and provided a well-ordered and institutionalized administrative machinery in Tamilakam. The development of strong local corporate bodies to manage local resources and the rise of temples as a major social institution were the two major developments in the history of early medieval Tamilakam which had a direct impact on the economy, especially on merchants, trade and mercantile institutions. This period also saw the Tamil kings engaging with the kingdoms of South-East Asia and Sri Lanka in a significant manner.

[Chapter 4](#) examines the institutions of the *nagaram*, a ‘corporate assembly of merchants’, and the guild in relation to the synergy provided by temples as the major integrative institution in Tamil society, in addition to

the activities and trade conducted by the merchants as individuals. As noted, the lack of a cohesive political structure or strong, centralized kingdoms did not necessarily negatively impact trade and commerce. However, the existence of a centralized and powerful state and political stability led to the evolution of strong institutional structures which led to greater levels of commercial activity, and paved the way for the rise of a more modern economy of merchant capitalists and commercial institutions.

[Chapter 5](#) brings together all these insights into an overview of the Tamil merchants and trade over one thousand years.

2. Trade and Merchants in Ancient Tamilakam

TAMILAKAM: AN INTRODUCTION

THE TAMIL REGION of India, situated strategically in the Indian Ocean between South-East and West Asia, has a long history of trade going back more than two millennia. But what exactly did the term Tamilakam, or Tamil region, denote? According to the Tamil epic *Silappadikaram*:¹

The Tamil region extends from the hills of Vishnu [Tirupati] in the north to the oceans at the cape in the south. In this region of cool waters were the four great cities of Madurai with its towers; Uraiyur which was famous; tumultuous Kanchi; and Puhar with the roaring waters [of the river Kaveri and the ocean].

Geographically, therefore, the Tamil region denoted peninsular India south of the Deccan plateau, extending from the Bay of Bengal in the east to the Arabian Sea in the west.

The notion of Tamilakam was based on a larger linguistic and cultural identity and did not denote a single political identity or nation state. Traditionally, the Tamil region was said to be ruled by *muvenḍar*, the three kings: Pandya, Chola and Chera. Madurai, Uraiyur, which is now a suburb of Tiruchi, and Vanji (modern Karur)² were the respective capitals of the three kingdoms. To these should be added the kingdom in the north, with its capital in Kanchi or Kanchipuram, which was later ruled by the Pallavas. In addition to the capital cities, many ports along the eastern coast are mentioned in Sangam literature. Foremost among them was Puhar, also known as Pumpuhar or Kaveri(pum)pattinam, situated at the mouth of one of the distributaries of the Kaveri and the sea, north of Nagapattinam, which was often described as *managaram*, the great city. Many other ports are also mentioned in Sangam poems. In addition, archaeological evidence has

established that Arikamedu or Virampatnam, just south of Pondicherry, and Alagankulam near Rameswaram, though it is no longer on the sea, were ports visited by Roman traders.³ The ports more frequently mentioned in foreign accounts were on the west coast. Musiri or Muziris was the major port of the Chera kingdom (modern Kodungallur, earlier known as Cranganore)⁴ from where pepper was exported. Further to the north was the port of Tyndys or Tondi (now known as Ponnani), not to be confused with the port of the same name on the east coast in the Pandyan kingdom.

In spite of the poetic hyperbole about the three ‘kings’ and their extended authority, in reality, during the ancient period, the ‘kingdoms’ were principalities ruled by warring chieftains.⁵ Such smaller political units were constantly looking to augment their resource base, necessitated by the narrow limits of their territorial authority. Frequent military campaigns and conquests of territory, especially from the *velir*, petty chieftains, were thus a feature of the political history of the region. Thus, in Sangam poetry, the warrior king was the metaphor for a great king of heroic qualities and for great kingship. Neduncheliyan, the Pandya king; Tirumavalavan, the Chola king; Senguttuvan, the Chera king; and Ilantiraiyan, the ruler of Kanchi⁶ as well as minor chieftains are all eulogized for their great qualities as leaders of their armies and for their conquests.

Notwithstanding the instability inherent in this fragmented political landscape and the frequent occurrences of military conflict in the region, there seems to have been no significant or noticeable disruption of trade in the region, either in internal or in coastal trade. Literary works confirm this. Our reconstruction of external trade is further substantiated by stronger evidence from archaeological data and contemporary foreign accounts. The resilience of trade independent of political stability was a remarkable feature of ancient Tamilakam.

TRADE AND MANUFACTURE

Trade was recognized as the engine of growth and economic well-being in Tamilakam. Old texts listed six pre-eminent economic activities—cultivation, manufacturing, trade, pictorial art, learning and sculpture. This

list also gives an insight into the cultural priorities and the ambience of the region. However, the consensus among most commentators and scholars was that cultivation and trade were the two most important economic activities,⁷ and certainly the most significant in terms of volume.

Contemporary poets, for instance, referred to persons who had grown rich on cultivation and trade.⁸ Linking agriculture with commerce also indicates that the surplus generated in agriculture, the largest sector, was mobilized through trade, providing the much-needed capital resources for commercial activities.⁹ Nevertheless, more advanced levels of trade coexisted with a large and extensive subsistence economy in Tamilakam. Only the former lends itself to analysis, however, especially because of its potential to trigger sustained economic growth.

Ports and maritime trade: The literary evidence

Maritime trade contributed in a visible and significant manner to the total trade of ancient Tamilakam. This is reflected in the vivid descriptions of trade and shipping in Sangam literature, which often mentioned the ships of the *yavana* or merchants from Rome. These ships brought commodities from Rome which were exchanged for pepper and other products of the Tamil region. ‘Well-built yavana ships came with gold to prosperous Musiri and left with pepper.’ These ships also brought to the Pandyan kingdom ‘cool scented wine’ which was much desired by the people and made them happy.¹⁰

Ports were naturally major trade centres where all the circuits of trade—overseas, overland and coastal—converged, and where people of varied nationalities speaking diverse languages met. Most of the ports described in Sangam literature were on the east coast of Tamilakam.¹¹ In the Pandya kingdom, Korkai was the southernmost port, situated in the Gulf of Mannar. It was the centre of pearl fishing, where the oysters had pearls as large as teeth.¹² To the north, also in the Gulf of Mannar, was Saliyur, where:

Clouds hang over the sea; the wind sounds like drums; ships with flags sail into the harbour bringing fine goods like gold which are used by everyone. Over the harbour the

lowering clouds look like mountains. Saliyur, which had the same name as a fine variety of rice, and was encircled by the ocean as its moat, was conquered by Neduncheliyan.¹³

The same poem also noted that all along the coast in the Pandya kingdom:

People who sail their ships across the oceans come together and sell the horses they bring in exchange for the goods brought by coastal ships. The Pandya kingdom had many prosperous coastal towns with boats carrying fine pearls, conch bangles, many varieties of grain, white salt, tamarind and dried fish, and their number increased day by day.¹⁴

The port of Tondi was in the Palk Strait to the north of Rameswaram.¹⁵

At Tondi, merchants bring eaglewood, cloth, sandalwood, camphor and other fragrant substances in their ships across the wide seas. The eastern air [blowing] from Tondi brings these scents to Madurai, the city of the Pandyan.¹⁶

Judging by the number of ports in the Gulf of Mannar and Palk Straits which are mentioned in Sangam poetry, it can be inferred that in the ancient period ships were able to sail along the west coast of Sri Lanka since they were smaller, whereas even in the seventeenth century ships were larger and had to sail around the eastern coast of Sri Lanka.

The most important port on the east coast undoubtedly was Puhar, which was described in great detail in *Pattinappalai* and *Silappadikaram*.

Puhar is of undying fame, protected by the gods. It is filled with horses brought in ships; sacks of pepper brought on carts; gemstones and gold from the northern mountains; sandalwood and eaglewood from the western hills; pearls from the southern seas; coral from the eastern seas; wheat from the Gangetic region, rice from the Kaveri plains; food from Sri Lanka and gold from Kadaram.¹⁷ Puhar has broad streets piled with rare and expensive goods.

In Puhar, boats are anchored along the shore like a row of tethered horses. They come with rice which is exchanged for the price of white salt ... In the harbour, the anchored ships with flags on the masts resembled tethered elephants.¹⁸

In this town lived many merchants who brought in wonderful and expensive goods from other countries across the seas on large ships and overland on carts and carried on their trade here Along the seafront was the beautiful sight of heaps of goods; and of anchored ships with their cargo.¹⁹

Further north were the ports of Eyirpattinam, which had a fort wall and where eaglewood was brought by sea,²⁰ and Pattinappakkam, where ships came from the north with horses with milk-white manes and other consumption goods.²¹

These descriptions provide valuable insights into the patterns of trade. There was a flourishing trade in food grains, and urban markets had a special street devoted to the sale of food grains, of which there were ‘eight, sixteen or eighteen varieties of grains’. In addition to what was locally produced, food grains were also imported. The commodities brought through land routes from the interior to the coast were primarily pepper, eaglewood, sandalwood and gemstones, while salt was the main product carried from the coast to the interior. The patterns of trade were also indicative of the natural products of the different eco-zones of the Tamil region. A distinctive feature of Sangam poetry was the classification of these zones under five *tinai*s—*neydal* or coastal, *marudam* or cultivated plains, *palai* or desert, *mullai* or pastoral, and *kurinji*, the hills. While these *tinai*s were primarily used by poets to evoke different moods, they also reflected the nature of economic activity and the products that characterized each zone. Thus salt and other marine products like pearls and fish came from the coast, while the hills produced aromatic woods and pepper. Food grains were grown in the cultivated plains, and all these products were exchanged extensively in internal trade.

Goods brought in by sea to the ports were also distributed in the hinterland through overland trade. Coastal trade was important, and mostly involved the import of food grains from further north along the Bay of Bengal, which were exchanged for white salt, a pattern of coastal trade that continued to be important even down to the nineteenth century. Pearls, dried fish, tamarind and conch-shell bangles were also shipped by small coastal craft which plied up and down the coast. There was a great deal of shipping activity in the Bay of Bengal. According to the *Periplus of the Erythrean Sea*, in the first century CE, three types of vessels were found in these waters—country ships trading along the coast; large vessels made of single logs bound together, called *sangara*; and the very large ships called *colandia* which made the voyage to Malaya and north to the Ganga.²²



Map 2.1 Capital Cities and Ports of Tamilakam: Sangam Period

There was a very high level of demand for aromatic products. Though eaglewood and sandalwood were both grown in the western hills, the supply was inadequate for the demand and both were also brought in from South-East Asia, in addition to camphor and incense from China and Indonesia. Coral was also an important import ‘from the eastern seas’. From the west, the main imports were gold, horses and wine. The ports on the east coast served both as entrepôts where products brought from overseas were exchanged for products brought by coastal vessels and as major markets where imported goods were traded in exchange for the main exports of the region—pepper, textiles, pearls and gem stones.

The dynamics of trade: Archaeological evidence

The descriptions in the literary accounts provide us with a detailed though static picture of trade in the ancient period. Accounts by foreign authors add depth to the reconstruction of trade. However, we need to turn to archaeological evidence to understand the inter-temporal dynamics of trade during the ancient period. Though the Tamil region had trade links with South-East Asia as well as with the west, the latter was better documented in contemporary accounts and also corroborated by archaeological evidence. Schoff noted that trade had been carried on between Egypt and India which extended to the Mediterranean region even in the pre-Roman period. The sea trade was controlled by the Arabs and Phoenicians and ‘the cloths and precious stones, the timbers and spices ... particularly cinnamon ... were redistributed at Socotra or Guardafi, and carried to the Nile and Mediterranean’. Even after Rome had replaced Alexandria as the centre of Mediterranean trade, Arabs still controlled the sea trade and protected their monopoly by making sure that their knowledge of the patterns of the monsoon winds and information about the direct sea route to India and about products traded remained their secret. Arab traders retained their knowledge monopoly about the source markets in India for cinnamon, the commodity which had made their fortunes, even after Roman ships began to sail directly to India.²³

The dynamics of trade between India and the Mediterranean changed due to many factors. Rome became the central power in the west and was the largest market for products from India. In the first century CE, Hippalus, an Egyptian pilot, ‘discovered’ the pattern of monsoon winds and the direct sea route to the west coast of India, which had been known only to Arab seafarers till then. This shortened the tedious and long voyage hugging the coast and also nullified the danger from the pirates who preyed on vessels in the coastal waters. Rome, as a policy measure, avoided the overland routes through Parthia and encouraged direct sea trade with India. This resulted in a significant increase in the total volume of Roman ships from barely twenty ships a year to almost a ship a day.²⁴

The increased volume of shipping reflected the growth in demand in Rome for commodities from India. Since the value of exports from Rome was much lower than the value of goods imported, the trade imbalance was made up in specie. Pliny, writing in 75 CE, complained that there was ‘no year in which India does not drain our Empire of at least fifty five million sesterces’.²⁵ In fact, trade with Rome peaked in the latter half of the first century CE during the reign of Tiberius, which is substantiated by the large share of the coins of Augustus and Tiberius among all the Roman coins found in India.²⁶

Tamilakam had been trading with Rome even when Rome was a republic. Roman artefacts, including coins of the Roman republic which have been dated to the third century BCE, have been excavated in Arikamedu, near Pondicherry, which was an ‘Indo-Roman trading station’,²⁷ and these establish conclusively the antiquity of the trade with Rome.

Roman ships did not sail beyond Cape Comorin until the early decades of the first century CE. Pliny’s account which depended on earlier authors for information on India mentioned no ports beyond the west coast.²⁸ During this period Roman traders travelled overland from the west coast through the Palghat pass to market centres in the east via Coimbatore, Erode and Karur. These districts were on the main trade routes linking the east coast with the west and served as major market centres. Besides, pepper and cardamom, the major exports, were grown in the western region. Beryl, a highly prized gem stone much in demand in Rome, came from mines in Kodumanal and Padiyur in Erode and Vaniyampadi near Salem. Excavations have also established that Chennimalai in Erode was a major centre for the production of iron and steel which were probably exported to Rome.²⁹ Remnants of furnaces and slag have been found in Chennimalai and Karur. All this explains why the finds of earlier Roman coins are concentrated in the districts of Coimbatore, Erode, Salem and Karur.³⁰

By the second half of the first century CE, Roman ships had begun to sail directly to ports on the east coast. *Periplus of the Erythrean Sea* was written at the same time as Pliny’s account, and is the factual firsthand account of a person who actually sailed to India and traded there. The *Periplus* describes

ports on the west and east coasts, showing that Roman traders had begun to access the eastern ports by sea. Ptolemy's *Geography*, written around 125 CE, lists ports on the Coromandel coast and also further east, an indication of the growing state of knowledge in the west about regions further east in Asia.³¹

According to the *Periplus*, the ports of Naura or Cannanore and Tyndys or Tondi were at the northern border of Tamilakam ('Damirica') and were ports in the Chera kingdom. To the south, Musiri also in the Chera kingdom, was an important port which 'abounds in ships sent ... from Arabia and the Greeks'. Nelcynda, near Kottayam, further south, was in the Pandyan kingdom.³² Large ships from the west came to these ports because of the vast quantities of pepper and malabathrum, the leaf of the cinnamon tree used as an aromatic, available there. Goods brought in by these ships included large quantities of coins, topaz, antimony, coral, crude glass, copper, tin and lead, some wine and a small quantity of textiles. The ships took back pepper, vast amount of pearls, ivory, silk cloth, spikenard, a fragrant ointment or oil from the Gangetic region, malabathrum from the interior, transparent stones, evidently beryls, diamonds, sapphire and tortoiseshell.³³ Tortoiseshell was brought to Musiri from islands near Malaya, and Schoff comments that this reference gave an accurate insight into the brisk trade of south India with South-East Asia.³⁴ This list of the exports from Rome and imports into Rome from Tamilakam clearly exemplifies the adverse trade balance of Rome due to the high value of the luxury goods imported from India, which had to be made up by the export of silver and gold coins.

A recently discovered papyrus, now in the Vienna Museum, dating to the second century CE, has a contract written in Greek between a merchant of Musiri and a merchant of Alexandria with respect to a shipment from Musiri. One side records a business loan drawn up in Musiri. The other side, written in Alexandria, lists the imports from Musiri—spikenard, ivory and bales of cloth. 'The business contract ... covers the period of shipment from Muziris until the arrival of the cargo at Alexandria and mentions the specific type of merchandise, the quantity and value as well as the 25 per

cent tax rate levied by Roman customs officials.’³⁵ The cargo amounted to 700 to 1700 pounds of spikenard, 4700 pounds of ivory items, and 790 pounds of varieties of textiles. The total value of this cargo was equal to the price of 2400 acres of land in Egypt.³⁶ The document clearly shows that individual merchant exporters operated on a large scale even in the ancient period. We can also see that trade in the ancient period was conducted over very long distances, either overland or by sea. Spikenard was also known as Gangetic nard, signifying that it came from the north of India, and yet it was being exported from a port on the south-west coast, situated diagonally across the country. Importantly, it gives an insight into the modalities of business arrangements in the ancient period. There were written contracts, covering the duration of the voyage and specifying the quantities and value of the goods traded. The reference to the business loan shows that long-term credit arrangements were in place and were used to enable the smooth functioning of trade.

Musiri, as we have seen, was also mentioned in Sangam literature and a poet said that at Musiri fish was bartered for rice brought in baskets; sacks of pepper were brought to the market from the houses; and the gold which came in the ships in exchange for the goods sold was brought on barges to the shore.³⁷

On the east coast, the *Periplus* noted, the important ports were Korkai, with the pearl fisheries. Further north and inland was the region of Uraiyur, ‘Argaru’, where all the pearls gathered on the coast were brought. From here came the muslins known as ‘Argaritic’ which were sent to Rome. The other ports on the Coromandel Coast mentioned in the *Periplus* have been identified as Puhar, Puducheri or Pondicherry and Sopatna.³⁸ The Tamil region, and especially the Chola kingdom, already had a thriving weaving industry and was famous for cotton textiles which were exported.

Arikamedu and Alagankulam, near Rameswaram were also ports where Roman ships came to trade. While the archaeological finds of Arikamedu are widely known, the beautiful graffito of a Roman ship on a piece of pottery at Alagankulam is less well known, and is further proof that Roman ships regularly visited the eastern ports. The ship has been identified as a

three-master Roman sailing ship of the first to third centuries CE, which was of the largest type of trading ships used on the long voyage to India.³⁹ These trading ports, Arikamedu, Alagankulam and Puhar, as well as the inland capital Madurai, had settled Roman colonies.⁴⁰

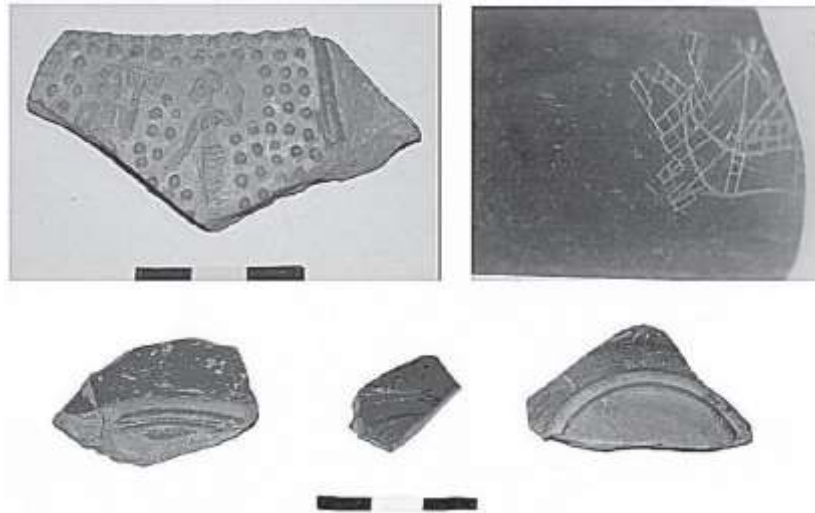


Figure 2.1 Alagankulam Potteries: Roman Influence
(Courtesy: Tamil Nadu State Department of Archaeology)

The pattern of trade between Rome and India began to change after the civil war following the death of Nero in 68 CE. Emperor Vespasian passed a series of laws against the luxurious lifestyle of the upper classes, and imports from India began to be largely confined to pepper and textiles, both comparatively low-value commodities. Luxury items like silk, ivory and beryl began to be traded increasingly in intra-Asian trade.⁴¹ The papyrus contract however indicates that luxury items like ivory continued to be imported into Rome from India even in the second century CE.

There was also a definite shift in the direction of Roman trade, and most of the trade after the first century CE was conducted with ports on the east coast. In addition to the internal problems of Roman politics, the patterns of trade also changed because the overland Silk Route on which silk was transported from China to Rome could not be used after the first century BCE as a result of the hostility of the Parthians in Central Asia. Chinese

silk, therefore, had to be transported by sea and was shipped to ports on the Coromandel Coast, which then served as entrepôts from where the silk was shipped to Rome.⁴²

The trade with South-East Asia and the commodities imported from there were often mentioned in Sangam literature. Trade links with China can only be deduced inferentially, from the references to the import of camphor and gold. Further, silk and silk yarn which was used in textile production must have been imported from China since the Tamil region did not produce any silk. If the references made by Pan Kou, an early Chinese writer, have been correctly interpreted, it would indicate that commercial intercourse between China and South India was already quite extensive in the second century BCE, and that the Chinese were well acquainted with the political and commercial conditions in India.⁴³

How were market exchanges conducted and price/value determined in trade? Though it has been argued that '[t]here is no evidence for transactions based on exchange value' and that all trade was conducted only on the basis of barter,⁴⁴ this does not seem tenable considering the realities of the logistics of long-distance maritime trade. It would have been impossible for trade to function on such a scale unless goods were exchanged for money. The enormous quantity of Chera coins that have been found on the bed of the river Amaravati in Karur also shows that money was definitely used as a medium of exchange. The finds ranged from copper coins dating to the second century BCE to silver portrait coins of the third century CE.⁴⁵

Roman coins were also in circulation in addition to local coins. Many Roman coins have a small countermark (dots, crescents, circles and even Roman letters). Slashed Roman coins have also been found, and though many theories have been offered no definitive conclusion is possible to explain why these marks were made. However, countermarked coins seem to have been stamped thus so that they could circulate as legally accepted money. Such countermarks would also serve the purpose of identifying the owner of the coins which were deposited with moneylenders, indicating that some form of banking services existed in the ancient period. Many

imitation Roman coins have also been discovered in many parts of India, arguably to be used in local circulation. There was no fraudulent or criminal intention behind minting these coins, and they equalled Roman coins in weight and purity of metal, and reveal a high degree of workmanship. These coins were probably made by an experienced Roman craftsman, or a skilled Indian craftsman trained by a Roman master.⁴⁶

The question that remains unanswered is why these Roman coins were in circulation as legal tender at all. It is probable that, with the great expansion of maritime trade in the first century CE, the demand for money also increased which could not be met by the volume of local currency then available. Since the quality of Roman coins was accepted universally, they were used to supplement the money supply then in circulation. The increase in trade in the first century CE would have placed many pressures on the economic resources of Tamilakam. To increase production in response to the growing demand would require the augmentation of all productive resources—inputs, labour and capital. Cotton cloth was the major manufactured commodity exported. Increasing output by increasing productivity was not possible in the absence of technological development. Thus output could only be increased by employing more factors of production—more cotton, spinners, weavers and looms. In the long run, therefore, this implies an expansion of economic activity in the region which was reflected in the pressures on money supply. The indigenous economy evidently also had the flexibility necessary for accommodating itself to the changing direction of trade. The reduction in the volume of demand in Rome for luxury products was offset by the increase in trade with South-East Asia and the Far East.

Manufactures

Contemporary literature indicates that many non-agricultural manufacturing activities were carried on in Tamilakam. Textile production was the largest activity next to agriculture in terms of output. Textiles remained the most important commodity of export from India and, in fact, held up Indian

manufacturing as the benchmark of excellence in global terms for nearly 2000 years. Weavers came from a community (later becoming a caste) known as Sali, and even today the Salis are predominant among the weaving castes in south India. Weavers lived in demarcated urban areas, and it can be said that the finer varieties of textiles used by the urban rich and for exports were woven by the urban weavers, whereas weavers in rural areas produced coarser cloth for local consumption. Many ancient texts noted that spinning of cotton yarn was done by women.⁴⁷ Spinning was a home-based occupation for women, and it remained so until the nineteenth century.

While the Salis wove the cloth, textiles were sold by merchants who specialized in the cloth trade, *aruvai vanikar*. In the cities there were demarcated streets for selling textiles, and the shops in Madurai had hundreds of scented saris stacked according to quality.⁴⁸ Weavers produced fine intricately designed silk and cotton fabrics, and wool from rat's hair, which was intended to give warmth.⁴⁹ Weaving of fine cloth was highly skilled work, and there are several references to the very thin, fine cloth woven with patterns. Such textiles were variously described as being so fine that the weave could not be discerned; as transparent and thin as snake skin; as fine as the vapour rising from milk. Fine cloth was kept scented with incense to keep it smelling fresh.⁵⁰

Metal work was an important craft and there are many references to brass and copper smiths working in cities. Jewellery making and gold work were also major activities and the craftsmen who did this work were distinct from merchants who traded in gemstones and gold. The artisans who worked in these metals, along with blacksmiths and masons, were known as the 'five' *kammalar* or *kanmalar*, and these occupational castes were prominent in Tamil society till recent times. The demand for the products and services of these artisans was very high in cities and in Puhar 'craftsmen from Magadha, Maratta artisans, masons from Avanti and yavana carpenters' had worked on the royal pavilion along with local craftsmen.⁵¹ A vivid picture of the variety of commodities that were available in cities is presented in the description of the main market of Madurai in *Silappadikaram*:

The market streets were heaped with many expensive goods that would be desired even by kings: covered carts, two wheeled carts, beautiful chariots, armour to cover the entire body, elephant goads set with gems, armguards made of leather, waist bands, balls of aromatic substances, white *chowris*, feather whisks, shields embossed with boar heads or forests, small leather shields, garlands made of pith, tools like saws, goods carved from ivory, scented paste and flower garlands.⁵²

The patterns of consumption in urban society created a demand for the services of a great variety of craftsmen and skills which contributed to the diversification of the economy.

Role of the state

It is difficult to define the role played by the state in promoting trade. On the positive side, the ruler, in this case the Pandyan king, was praised by the poet for ‘increasing the wealth of the ... people by procuring rare, valuable goods from various countries’. On the negative side, the military campaigns of the same king, Neduncheliyan, are listed, and the destruction caused by warfare and conquest is vividly described: ‘fertile agricultural lands are burnt and devastated and have turned into forests; places where cattle used to be raised have become the haunts for tigers; and settlements have been ruined’.⁵³ Whether the net balance was beneficial or not is thus open to question.

It was recognized that one of the main obligations of the state was to protect trade routes and traders from highway robbery and attacks. At least one poem in praise of Ilantiraiyan of Kanchi says that, in his country, there were no robbers who waylaid merchants and stole their goods because forest paths were guarded by soldiers with bows to protect merchants from attacks.⁵⁴ Nevertheless, the fact that merchants who travelled overland in groups were well armed to fight off robbers would indicate that such protection was minimal and that merchants depended on their own resources for security.

The state however was actively involved in collecting road tolls on goods carried overland⁵⁵ and customs duties on goods brought from overseas in the major ports. In Puhar:

Near the seashore filled with flowering cactus are the men who collect customs duties which are due to a good king. They work untiringly like the sun collecting taxes ... This is the rare street of the customs booth. There the officials stamp goods with the seal of the tiger [the Chola emblem]. On these sacks of expensive goods, guard dogs with sharp nails roam and play with goats. Such is Puhar.⁵⁶

At Puhar there was also a warehouse maintained by the government, which was known as *vellimadaimanram*.

Foreign merchants who came to Puhar had their goods stamped with their name, weight and measure and kept them in the warehouse. There were no guards at the entrance of the warehouse, nor were there doors with heavy bolts; nor did the owners of the goods guard their property. If anybody stole anything from the warehouse, they were made to walk around the city with the stolen goods on their heads and the goods were then confiscated. The warehouse made the people dread the thought of stealing.⁵⁷

Since the epic refers also to ‘the guards of the warehouse’,⁵⁸ the earlier passage may be taken to be poetic exaggeration of the power of the state in curbing robbers.

In the final analysis, trade thrived in the region mainly due to the attitude of all the states which did not impede trade though they may not have actively promoted it either. Foreign merchants were welcome to come and trade in the ports and inland cities and were allowed to live peacefully and conduct their business. Cities and ports are always described as cosmopolitan centres where many languages were heard, and the fact that people of different countries were not discriminated against in any way created an atmosphere that was conducive to trade.

MERCHANTS

In contrast to the data sources used in the account relating to trade in the ancient period, we rely almost exclusively on literary sources for a portrayal of merchants and mercantile activity. The use of literature as a historical source poses many problems, not the least of which is the subjective judgement of the researcher as to what extent the representation in the literary works represents reality and how much is idealized. Fortunately, contemporary inscriptions from the same period (around the beginning of the Common Era), though few in number, provide supplementary

information which adds more texture to the account drawn from the literary works. In spite of this, many questions remain unanswered on mercantile organization and the economics of trade with respect to sources of capital, the nature and requirements of credit, or even the extent of monetization. Some conclusions may be drawn inferentially but remain as hypotheses.

Social moorings

Merchants were prominent on the social and economic scene in Tamilakam, and were very active, especially in urban settlements. They were clearly held in high esteem in local society, in sharp contrast to the attitudes in cultures as far apart spatially and culturally as ancient Greece or medieval Japan, where commerce was looked down upon as a lowly occupation. In ancient Greece, gains from warfare and plunder was the noble ideal, while commerce was seen only in a negative light, and the common view was that trade was better left to foreigners like the Phoenicians.⁵⁹ Interestingly, although warfare and military aggression were equally valorized in Tamil culture, merchants were considered honoured and honourable members of society. *Pattinappalai*, one of the ten poems of the *Pattuppattu*, said of the merchants of Puhar:

The merchants of Puhar are as straightforward as the crosspiece of a yoke. They always speak the truth and are fair-minded, and fear ignominy. They value their goods and the goods of others by the same standard; they neither take too high a price for their goods, nor do they shortchange on what they sell. They openly state their profits on the various goods they handle. Such merchants have lived in Puhar for many years.⁶⁰

Another poem, *Maduraikkanchi*, praised the merchants of Madurai who were ‘virtuous householders’.⁶¹

These idealized representations surely reflected the positive attitude towards merchants which prevailed in Tamil society, which was due in no small part to the recognition that merchants, by making available a variety of goods not otherwise available locally, enabled higher levels of sophisticated consumption which contributed to an improved quality of life. ‘Merchants provide goods from the mountains and the seas which are of use and in great demand and give great happiness to the people.’⁶² In fact, the

contribution of merchants who had earned wealth and enjoyed a good reputation was acknowledged even by kings. In Madurai, the king honoured such merchants with the title of *etti* and a golden flower in recognition of this honour.⁶³

Furthermore, merchants were respected for their bravery and martial qualities, which were much admired in local culture.

They are hardworking; they wear footwear and body cover; because of their skill they are able to evade the arrows of highway robbers and have no scars of wounds on their chests; at their side they have shining swords with handles of ivory; they carry daggers on their waists which look like snakes; they wear tight clothes; they are brave warriors who will not turn their backs but will attack robbers with spears which they carry like [the God] Murugan.⁶⁴

The great respect for merchants as a community is evident in the *Silappadikaram*. The central characters of the epic, Kannagi and Kovalan, belonged to the leading merchant families of Puhar, and the tale begins with an announcement of their forthcoming marriage. Kannagi was the daughter of a merchant of the Manaykan family, who was ‘as generous as rainfall’. Kovalan’s father, who belonged to the merchant class known as Perunkudi, is described thus:

A rich merchant lived in Puhar who was held in great esteem by the Chola King as a leader among the local people. He helped many people with the money he earned from many righteous activities. His name was Masattuvan, and he also had an honorific title of ‘an elder with two fortunes’.⁶⁵

The *Silappadikaram* also noted that the rich merchants of Puhar were of good, virtuous families, and made donations to many charities.⁶⁶ Rich merchants were held in esteem because of their generosity and their contributions to the local community. They also supported local festivals and cultural activities, which secured their place in local society. Charitable donations by merchants are also recorded in the early inscriptions. Of the corpus of 116 inscriptions in Tamil Brahmi script which was in use till the early centuries of the Common Era, six refer to donations by merchants—four in Alagarmalai, to the north of Madurai, and two in Pugalur in Karur district, dating from the first century BCE to the third century CE.⁶⁷ These donor merchants are variously described as dealers in cloth, grain, oil and

salt and were unlikely to have ranked among the richest class of merchants. Yet, a part of their limited resources was devoted to charity. This was probably motivated by a complex mix of values, beliefs and self-interest. Donations to religious institutions, in this case Jain or Buddhist institutions, were believed to ensure spiritual merit. Additionally these earned recognition and legitimacy for the donor in local society, building social capital which aided them in their business.

Prosperous merchants also had a visible presence in the community because of their lavish lifestyles. The descriptions of merchants of Puhar and Madurai note that they lived in tall, multi-storey houses which had latticed windows to let in the breeze and open terraces. The houses were filled with expensive goods and artefacts worth crores and great quantities of food, where even the kites flying past would have liked to rest. Beautiful women dressed in fine clothes could be seen at the windows.⁶⁸

Evidently a high level of literacy prevailed in Tamil society in the ancient period. Merchants were highly literate and many noted poets were from the mercantile classes. One of the best known among them was Sattanar, the author of the second great Tamil epic *Manimekalai*, who was a grain merchant. *Mullaippattu*, one of the ten poems of the *Pattuppattu*, was composed by Nampudanar, a gold merchant. Many other poets were also referred to as merchants dealing in cloth, provisions and gold.⁶⁹ Since they were referred to as ‘merchants’, it is probable that they combined their literary activities with trade. Poets came from other occupational backgrounds also. Nakkirar, another famous poet, was from a conch-cutting family,⁷⁰ and, according to Puranic works in Tamil, was said to have even taken on an angry Siva in a literary debate. Poets also came from such diverse professions as medical practitioners and goldsmiths. This leads to a strong inference that literacy was widespread in Tamilakam in the ancient period, and was probably at a much higher level than in later centuries. It is therefore not surprising that merchants who contributed to literature were held in great esteem in a culture which valued learning.

Agents of economic growth

The term ‘merchant’ did not refer to a homogeneous group or class. While all people engaged in commerce were merchants, *vanikan*, they were, however, a highly differentiated group. At one end of the scale were the rich merchants operating in the ports and capital cities; at the other end were the peddlers who sold their wares on the streets. The largest and probably the most representative class was the single-commodity merchants often mentioned in literary works as well as in inscriptions. While caste was not unknown in ancient Tamil society, class was probably a stronger marker of identity among merchants than caste.

Many literary works and commentaries classified rich merchants into three subgroups, according to their wealth, as *Ippar*, *Kavippar* and *Perunkudi*.

If the Ippar, Kavippar and Perunkudi merchants stood under an umbrella, mounted respectively on an elephant, a bull or in their footwear, and all their wealth was piled around them, they would not be able to see anything over the piles.⁷¹

While Ippar and Kavippar were probably only lexical terms, Perunkudi merchants are referred to in the literary works. The father of Kovalan, the hero of *Silappadikaram*, was a Perunkudi merchant, and his family background was often mentioned to establish the Kovalan’s high social status, for instance when Kannagi went to the Pandyan king to protest his unjustified execution.

The rich merchants dealt in goods imported from overseas, as well as in goods brought overland from the interior. The *Silappadikaram* noted that ‘the great city of Puhar was filled with many merchants who brought in rare and expensive goods from other countries over seas and over land in ships and carts and carried on their trade’.⁷² This would indicate that the big merchants were also ship owners who were engaged in maritime trade, though it has been argued that there is no evidence that the Tamil people engaged directly in ship owning or maritime trade.⁷³ Although the *Periplus* refers to the ships in coastal and long-distance trade, this does not necessarily mean that the ships were owned by the Tamil merchants. This is

an instance where the literary reference needs further exploration for well-authenticated historical information.

Trade on such a large scale would require a large reserve of capital and considerable business skills. But there is no information as to how this was managed. What was the resource base of the merchants? How did they raise the capital that they needed? What were the arrangements for obtaining credit? We can only make some logically consistent inferences in answering these questions.

Unlike the commodity merchants, the rich merchants dealt in many commodities. They did not enter into retail trade and functioned as wholesale agents for imported and exported goods. Since they are mentioned as active in overland trade, it would be safe to assume that they organized themselves in groups and carried on overland trade in caravans. For instance, it has been conjectured that the name of Kovalan's father, Masattuvan was derived from his function as *mahasarthavaha* or the leader of caravans.⁷⁴ Furthermore, merchant guilds were well known in ancient India. Two inscriptions dating from the second century BCE from Mangulam in north Madurai and a pottery inscription from Kodumanal in Erode district also referred to *nigamam* or merchant guilds. The *nigamattar*, members of the guild, acting jointly, had carved the stone beds in a cave in Mangulam.⁷⁵ The geographical distribution of the inscriptions confirms that the practice of merchants organizing themselves in guilds was widespread.

What were the advantages of the guild as an organization? Being a part of a group lessened risk in two ways. One, it minimized the physical danger of long-distance travel, which was of grave concern while travelling through unsettled and unprotected tracts of the country. It also addressed the disadvantage of trading as an individual merchant, especially in markets in distant lands. The group could also be a possible source of credit for individual members to tide over any short-term needs. Finally, a group identity engendered greater trust in all societies, and members belonging to a guild were perceived to be less risk-prone than individual merchants.

More numerous were the commodity merchants. Contemporary inscriptions refer to merchants dealing in seven different commodities—

aruvai, cloth; *pon*, gold; *kula*, grains; *uppu*, salt; *ennai*, oil; *kolu*, ploughs; and *panitam*, jaggery.⁷⁶ Literary sources also refer to these merchants who mostly conducted their business from their shops in the cities. City streets were segregated according to designated commodities like textiles, gold or grain and such segregation was a characteristic of urban centres all over India till very recent times.

In general, merchants were distinct from artisans or craftsmen who produced or manufactured goods for consumption. Trading was therefore in itself a specialized function requiring specific skills and knowledge. *Silappadikaram* gives a detailed description of the market area of Madurai where each street was devoted to a single product. In the street where gems were sold:

Flawless diamonds with all the five major attributes as decreed in the ancient texts glowed like the rainbow in white, red, green and dark colours; similarly, there were flawless emeralds; four varieties of perfect rubies; *pushparaga*; honey coloured carnelians which looked like the rays of the sun; sapphires as dark as the night; *gometakam* in red and yellow ...

Round pearls white and red like Mars which were free from flaws due to air, sand, stone or water; corals which were not flawed with holes or bent because of being caught in rocks under water. In the street where these nine varieties of gems were sold, the merchants were highly skilled in assessing the value and quality of these gemstones; because of their perfection, this street would never be destroyed by enemies.⁷⁷

Similarly, in the street of the gold merchants, four varieties of gold were sold and the merchants were experts in identifying each variety. Flags were planted as markers to guide buyers so that they would not get confused as to where each variety was being sold.⁷⁸ In the street where textiles were sold, hundreds of scented saris woven intricately with silk and cotton yarn and wool (rat's hair) were stacked according to variety and quality in the shops.⁷⁹ It is clear that these merchants were not the artisans who produced the final goods for the market. Gemstone cutters and jewellers, goldsmiths and weavers were craftsmen with their own special skills. The merchants were specialized traders who were knowledgeable and skilled in assessing the quality and varieties of the commodities that they handled.

The use of flags to identify shops and the goods sold was a common business strategy which served to advertise to the buyers where specific goods would be available. This was particularly true of toddy shops which were found in large numbers in all the cities. In fact, it was noted that the flags marking toddy shops in Puhar were so numerous that sunlight could not penetrate their dense shade.⁸⁰

The *umanar*, salt merchants, were itinerant merchants as opposed to the other commodity merchants who sold their goods in city markets. Sangam poems have wonderfully evocative passages which described the travelling salt merchants. The carts of the salt merchants were drawn by strong bullocks wearing garlands made of pith. Monkeys went along in formation with the carts and played with the children of the salt merchants who were travelling with their parents.⁸¹

The carts were covered with mats of palmyra leaves, and [each] carried a hen coop on top of the thatch. A small grinding stone and a jar of pickle were slung on the side of the cart which was driven by the wife of the salt merchant who cradled her child in her arms. The merchants had broad, beautiful muscular shoulders. Bullocks were yoked to the crossbar with strong ropes. The merchants went along the carts, guarded them and saw to it that they went in formation ... They travelled with their many bullocks on a long road which went to many towns.⁸²

It is instructive to reconstruct the economics of the trade in salt. To begin with, the salt merchants, unlike the other commodity merchants, were also involved in salt manufacture.⁸³ Since salt was a low-priced basic necessity of mass consumption, it would not lead to any great value addition through differentiated processes of production and distribution. Salt was essentially location specific in that it was produced only in the coastal areas. The Sangam poems invariably mentioned that ships which had come into the ports with various commodities would exchange them for 'white salt'. However, since salt was consumed universally, it had to be transported overland to all the interior areas. These journeys must have taken many months, which was why the salt merchants travelled with their families, and their carts were virtually their mobile homes. This practice also helped internalize the transport costs for the merchants.

Salt is an essential ingredient for cooking, though it is only consumed in small quantities, as the poets also pointed out. Since it was not a high-priced commodity, the merchants would have operated with only a small profit margin on the base price. Their returns therefore could come only from bulk sales and travelling with their carts enabled them to carry salt in large quantities. On the demand side, a regular supply of salt at specified intervals was not assured throughout the countryside since the inland settlements were totally dependent on the itinerant merchants for their requirements. They would therefore have had to buy salt in large quantities to see them through relatively long periods.

Pepper was the only other commodity mentioned in long-distance overland trade; it was brought from the west in baskets shaped like jackfruit, on pack donkeys.⁸⁴ Yet, a great many commodities must have been transported overland, from the ports to the hinterland, to distribute the goods brought in on ships in coastal and long-distance maritime trade, and in the reverse direction, carrying goods from the interior to the ports to be exported. This, in fact, is mentioned in many of the poems.

Overland travel involved danger because of attacks by highway robbers. Though the king Ilantiraiyan was eulogized for maintaining the safety of roads in his kingdom by deploying soldiers armed with bows along forest paths to deter highway robbers, the same poet more realistically also described the bravery of the merchants who armed themselves to fight off highwaymen.⁸⁵ Travelling in groups or caravans and being well armed to repel attacks were the strategies adopted to manage the risks of long-distance overland trade.

Urban marketplaces bustled with brisk activity throughout the day and in the evening. Many craftsmen and artisans produced goods ranging from jewellery and gold to brass- and copper-ware, leather work and ornamental artefacts made of pith, which they sold directly to buyers from their shops. At the lower end of the price scale were people who made and sold food items to the townsfolk and peddlers who sold scented pastes and cosmetics.

Strangely, brokers or intermediaries are rarely mentioned though their services would have been indispensable in markets characterized by highly

imperfect information, especially in view of the large number of foreign traders who came to trade in the region. The *Silappadikaram* refers to people who rendered ‘small services’⁸⁶ who might have been offering brokerage services. In Madurai, brokers roamed day and night along the street of the grain market, with weighing scales and measures.⁸⁷

Foreign traders and merchant diaspora

Because of the voluminous trade carried on with Rome, foreign merchants were very visible in the port cities. Though in general the term yavana was supposed to refer to the Romans, in reality, the yavana were probably traders and sailors of many nationalities from the eastern Mediterranean region. In Puhar:

In the harbour area was the quarters of the yavana whose eye-catching goods were in great demand. Foreign traders who had left their native places and come here to make money, sailing their ships across dark seas, lived in residential quarters close to the sea, as if they were all of one nationality.⁸⁸

It was noted that ‘on the beachfront lived the merchants who had come overseas to trade’.⁸⁹ These merchants traded on their own account, and their goods were stamped with their name, weight and measure and kept in the official warehouse.⁹⁰ In the coastal areas of the Pandya kingdom, ‘people who sail their ships across the oceans come together and sell their horses in exchange for goods brought by the coastal ships’.⁹¹ But foreign traders also travelled inland, and were often seen in Madurai, the largest city in Tamilakam. That cities were multicultural centres where many languages were heard was evidently a source of pride, and the fact was repeated several times by the Sangam poets. However, the Tamils as the host society displayed an ambivalent attitude towards the foreign merchants who needed to stay for extended periods in Tamilakam. In Puhar, for instance, while the foreign merchants were allowed to trade freely, they had to live in a separate settlement which segregated them from the local residents. There are several references in Sangam poems to yavana, but it can be seen that the attitude towards the yavana was often hostile, and that they were

considered an alien, even barbaric, people who spoke a harsh-sounding language.⁹² This instinctive suspicion of the foreigner persisted even though many yavana and other foreigners who came from across the seas had stayed on in the Tamil region and worked in various capacities, often as skilled craftsmen. The fortress gate of the city of Madurai was guarded by yavana carrying large swords,⁹³ while the inner apartment of the king was guarded by deaf-mute *mlecchas*, barbarians.⁹⁴ There are references to yavana metal workers as ‘hard-eyed yavana’ (perhaps because they had grey or blue eyes) who fashioned tiger chains with strong links and lamps,⁹⁵ and of yavana carpenters who worked on the royal pavilion in Puhar.⁹⁶ Trade thus paved the way for migration and cross-cultural interchange.

There are almost no references in the literary sources to Tamil merchant diaspora in overseas settlements. Sri Lanka (Ilam) and Java (Savakam) were frequented by the Tamil people, and Buddhism was the overarching unifying factor which brought together the three countries. Gajabahu, the king of Sri Lanka, came to worship at the temple dedicated to Kannagi built by the Chera king Chenguttuvan.⁹⁷ Java, in particular, is mentioned almost as if it were an extension of Tamilakam, indicating steady commercial and cultural intercourse. However there is some evidence that the Tamil people did travel and live in other parts of South-East Asia. A stone with a Tamil Brahmi inscription dating to the third or fourth century CE has been discovered in Thailand. The inscription referred to a goldsmith and the stone has been identified as the touchstone of a goldsmith,⁹⁸ suggesting that people from Tamilakam travelled to centres in South-East Asia to live and trade there.

URBANIZATION

Urbanization was a natural concomitant of trade, of an economy which had diversified beyond subsistence into producing for a market. The process of urbanization was built on several prerequisites which included a well-developed agricultural sector, a diversified economy, physical structures like buildings and monuments and a complex social structure.⁹⁹ What are the sources which will help to reconstruct the urban landscape and the

process of urbanization? Many ports and inland towns found mention in contemporary foreign accounts (Ptolemy, *Periplus*) and have also been identified in archaeological excavations. However, we need to go to the descriptions in literary works not only to understand the urban topography and how cities functioned, but also to relive the essence of urban living in ancient times.

The major inland cities mentioned in the Sangam poems, that is, the four capital cities of Madurai, Karur (Vanji), Uraiyur and Kanchi, continue to exist even today, though the ruins of the ancient city of Madurai are located to the south of the present city, and Uraiyur is now a suburb of Tiruchi, across the river Kaveri. Most of the ports, however, have dwindled to coastal villages though the settlements can be identified. This might have happened due to two factors. First, the Coromandel Coast historically did not have any natural harbours. Coastal settlements grew to be important ports for various external reasons, mostly political, and faded into obscurity once the political situation changed. Second, there have been changes to the coastline because of natural phenomena like the sea receding in some parts or giant tidal waves causing destruction. The total eclipse of Puhar as a major trade emporium and as a port is a case in point.

The cities of the ancient period were probably not very large, though some were described as managaram or the great city. For instance, in *Silappadikaram*, an angry Kannagi seeking to avenge the death of Kovalan ‘went around Madurai thrice’, suggesting that the city covered a relatively small area. But in the final analysis, there was a clear perception that the city represented a pattern of settlement which was distinct and different from rural habitats.

Cities were characterized by a concentration of population and economic activities. All cities, including ports, were protected by defensive fortress walls which were so constructed that vats of boiling oil could be poured on attacking armies and archers could shoot them without being targeted themselves. In all the cities, houses are invariably described as tall structures ‘reaching to the sky’, with windows to let in the breeze and terraces where residents could enjoy moonlit nights. However stylized this

description might be it probably represented the reality of houses huddled in a relatively restricted space. Such tall buildings with windows are depicted in sculptures in ancient historical sites like Sanchi.

The hustle and bustle of cities is best captured in the descriptions of Puhar, the premier port, and Madurai, the great capital. Many features were common to both cities: the organization of urban space, segregation of residential and commercial areas, as well as separate areas or streets assigned for various occupations and traders, and the visible presence of foreigners speaking many languages, all of which are described many times.



Statue of the Buddha
recovered from the sea



Wharf in Puhar

Figure 2.2 Poompuhar Excavations
(Courtesy: Tamil Nadu State Department of Archaeology)

Puhar

Puhar was divided into two main areas, Maruvurpakkam along the sea and Pattinappakkam which was further inland. Maruvurpakkam, where the foreign merchants including the yavana had their quarters, was primarily the commercial area. Here peddling traders roamed the streets selling coloured and aromatic pastes and incense; weavers had their own quarters; broad streets were piled so high with silk, coral, sandalwood, eaglewood, flawless pearls, precious gems and gold that they could not be measured;

heaps of grain and many other goods lined the streets; areas were segregated for people selling sweets, fish, toddy, white salt, meat and oil. There was also a separate area where artisans like brass- and copper-smiths, jewellers, tailors, leather workers and others lived.¹⁰⁰ In Pattinappakkam lived the rich Perunkudi merchants, as well as Brahmins who recited the Vedas, farmers, doctors and astrologers. Though some artisans such as pearl jewellers and conch cutters also lived in this district, the residents were primarily engaged in various service activities like bards, dancers, courtesans and prostitutes. Soldiers and men who rode horses and elephants lived outside the fort,¹⁰¹ and were presumably intended to defend the port.

The market street was between these two districts where the voices of the buyers and sellers of goods were heard continuously.¹⁰² Perhaps the ambience and energy of Puhar are best captured in the description of the harbour area at night:

Traders had lit lamps in their shops selling coloured pastes, flowers, cosmetic powders and eatables. The lights in the places of the skilled goldsmiths who made jewellery; the rows of lights kept by merchants selling sweet dishes; lamps on top of pots put up by merchants who sold other eatables; lamps lit by women selling toddy; the lights of the fish sellers; the lighthouse which guided ships at sea; the lamps kept by fishermen in their boats; by people from various countries; by the guards of the warehouse, Puhar was lit up with all these lights.¹⁰³

Puhar was administered by five groups of state officials and eight corporate assemblies.¹⁰⁴ This administrative framework probably functioned throughout the region including rural settlements, and the village assembly was referred to in an ancient inscription.¹⁰⁵ According to the *Manimekalai* Puhar was virtually destroyed by a tidal wave with much loss of life, an occurrence described as *kadal kol* or taken by the sea. The theme of loss occasioned by the sea is a recurrent one in historical memory in Tamil culture, and the loss of a significant volume of early literary works in Tamil is usually attributed to a major incursion by the sea. We can only close with a hypothesis: was this the reason for the decline of Puhar as a port?

Madurai

Madurai was universally accepted as the oldest city in Tamilakam. Also referred to as Kudal, it was famous for its towers and was known as *nanmadakkudal*, the city of four towers; *kodimadakkudal*, the city of towers with flags; and as the city with beautiful chariots.¹⁰⁶ Madurai was encircled by a fearsome fortress wall surrounded by a moat and a strong hedge. There was an underground passage beneath the moat which was wide enough for an elephant to cross to reach the fort gate. Guarded by yavana carrying large swords, Madurai looked as grand as the opened jewellery casket of Indra himself.¹⁰⁷ Madurai was so large and populous that, 'like the ocean, which does not overflow or dry up, Madurai with its towers did not diminish when people took goods away nor did it become overcrowded when more and more people came in ... Madurai is as immeasurable as the Ganga flowing into the sea, with ships bringing tribute and many goods each day.'¹⁰⁸

Poets noted that the high level of activity in the cities was reflected in a high volume of noise.

In the street of the day market, the sounds in the evening were as loud as when a festival was being celebrated in Madurai with its towers ... Merchants from foreign countries unload the goods they have brought by ship to exchange [them] for gems and jewellery. These sounds mingle with the sounds from the city, and the noise from the evening shops resembles the chatter of birds returning to their nests.¹⁰⁹

Courtesans were an important part of urban society. *Silappadikaram* has lengthy descriptions of courtesans, their accomplishments and their lifestyles in Puhar and Madurai. According to the sociocultural values of ancient Tamilakam, courtesans were not looked down upon as social outcasts; on the contrary, they were esteemed members of society who added to the quality of life in urban areas. Though they were described as women who did not have husbands or cohabit with only one partner, they were seen as being different and much superior to prostitutes 'who sold themselves each day'.

There were many temples in Puhar and Madurai. There were temples to major Hindu deities like Siva, Vishnu, Murugan and Balarama. Several traditional, indigenous deities and supernatural spirits were also venerated

and worshipped. Besides these, Buddhism and Jainism were important religions in Tamilakam. Madurai, for instance, had temples dedicated to Mahavira and Buddha.¹¹⁰ In fact, these two religions were central to the two major Tamil epics *Silappadikaram* and *Manimekalai*.

What were the factors behind urbanization? It is important to understand that the level of urban development should not be overstated, in spite of the literary references to the vigour and vitality of cities. In fact, only two types of urban settlements are mentioned in Sangam literature—capital cities in the interior and ports on the coast. The description in *Silappadikaram* of the route taken by Kovalan and Kannagi from Puhar to Madurai in search of a new start in their life mentions only one city—Uraiyur, the Chola capital. Otherwise, the couple went through fertile agricultural land crossing many waterways and villages. Tamilakam was predominantly rural with limited urbanization. Commerce was the driving force behind the development of ports, while capital cities were the seats of political authority.¹¹¹

But one must be careful also not to underestimate the economic dynamics of urbanization in Tamilakam. Ancient Tamilakam had achieved a high level of economic activity given the technological constraints of the time. Trade had evolved as a specialized activity, distinct from production. The extent of maritime trade and contact with overseas markets from Rome to China was reflected in a high level of mercantile activity. While it is true that cities were not numerous, they nevertheless contributed significantly to the development of a variety of manufactures and skilled crafts. The urban environment in which merchants of many nations were free to live and trade without hindrance and where many religions coexisted and flourished reflected the positive attitude of the Tamil kings towards trade and business.